

Palm Centro

Palm OS Comes To The Masses

The Palm Centro is the latest Palm with their Palm OS, unlike the other models that we've tested in the recent past that were based on Microsoft's Windows Mobile.

The initial reaction to the phone is that it seems like a very casual hip-looking phone. It's not the most compact of phones we've seen but its pretty decent for a phone that comes with a fully usable keypad.

The build quality is a little shabby. While holding it one hand, you can feel the back cover squeeze from the pressure. The stylus supplied with the phone is very light. It won't break, but it bends while using and it doesn't have a great feel. The keys on the keypad are really small, but are reasonable for



typing. There is no virtual keyboard, should you want to use it to type.

The interface is a little confusing if you're used to Windows Mobile and Symbian phones. Closing programs and switching to other programs is hectic as well. The SMS and messaging interface looks great—so does the phone dialler itself. The software itself is fast and reacts well. The design—colours and fonts used in the interface doesn't match up to fancy Symbian and Windows Mobile applications and it looks pretty outdated.

Reception is good and so is the voice quality, but the sound is really flat and a fair bit different from other phones. The 1.3-MP camera is nothing extraordinary, but is decent for occasional urgent photos.

Finally, it comes down to the price of the phone and that's where the Palm Centro has a chance. The phone has an MRP of Rs 13,990. For a similar

price, you can easily get Windows Mobile phones with larger screens. In the Centro, you get a proper phone with a proper keypad, a compact but great screen and for a bit of the geek factor—Palm OS, which is still uncommon in India.

Specifications:
320 x 320 65k colour touch screen, MicroSD slot, 1.3 MP camera, Bluetooth, IR, Supports GPRS, GSM, EDGE and CSD. Dimensions: 10.72 x 5.36 x 1.86cm, Weight: 116gms

Contact: Palm Inc.
Phone: 011-41725228/9
E-mail: myil.nathar@palm.com
Web site: www.palm.com
Price: Rs 13,990

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Gigabyte 9800GX2 GV-NX98X1GHI-B

The GX2 Returns After An Absence In The 8 Series

Two PCBs in one—now that's something that the GeForce 8 series was missing out on. We never got to see an 8800GX2 in action. The Gigabyte's 9800GX2 is the first such card we look at. It's been a while since we've seen something this huge and heavy. Like all 9 series of GeForce cards, it's a 65-nm card, but this comes with 1 GB of RAM.

In dimensions, it's as long as the 8800GTX or 9800GTX, the 9800GX2 is thick, but flat with the fan concealed within the unit. Fortunately, the card takes two slots just like the GTX cards. In terms of power, an 8-pin and 6-pin power connectors are required, unlike two 6-pin power connector configuration for the 8800GTX.

It performs faster than any 8800Ultra out there, and

it annihilates them even more once you go higher resolutions. The card scores 18517 points in 3DMark 2006 and 13398 in 3DMark 2005. For example, on our test rig, in games such as Splinter Cell, the GX2 is a considerable 27 per cent faster than the 8800Ultra. At resolutions of 1600 x 1200, this lead increases to close to 44 per cent. The trend is the same through most of the games. It's not just the 8800Ultra that are beaten. Even the latest 9800GTX's we've tested stand no chance.

The 9800GX2 does get very hot, and that can be easily made out by the blast of hot air coming from the rear of the card. Should you buy this card, you must also invest in a decent cabinet with decent cooling. A power supply of at least 600 W is also recommended for this card.



The price for the Gigabyte 9800GX2 is Rs 34,000, which makes it a very expensive investment. The Gigabyte 9800GX2 is a fast card. We've seen it bypassing the 8800Ultras in all our tests. For users using 24-inch screens and running games at resolutions of 1920 x 1200 or higher, the advantage of a card like this is clearly noticeable and these are the users for whom it makes good sense to buy this card. However, if you already have an SLI board, it would be a much cheaper and most probably a better option to pair two

8800GTs or 8800GTSes together.

Specifications:
nVidia GeForce 9800 GX2, 1 GB GDDR3 memory, PCI-E 2.0x16

Contact: Technology and Gadgets
Phone: 22-2382331/2
E-mail: vikas@technologyandgadgets.com
Web site: www.technologyandgadgets.com
Price: Rs 34,000

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Epson Stylus C110

Slightly Overpriced, Average Printer For The Home User



The Stylus C110 is a piezo-electric inkjet printer from Epson. Its price point and design is aimed for the home user.

It's a decent looking printer, which will definitely fit in well with the rest of the computer setup, but it isn't the most compact of printers. There are five cartridges in all, out of

which two are black. The entire printer installation and setup is simple and straightforward.

In terms of quality, there are a few issues. There's fine banding throughout all the print qualities selected—more prominent in the lower quality prints. At low quality, the print speed is pretty good. Colour accuracy

wasn't too good either. As compared to some other printers, the colours were a little washed out. The yellows, especially had a very different tone—they appeared much lighter than yellow. On the other hand, dark browns and purples appear black. Our photo quality test print took a little over three and a half minutes to complete.

The prints come out pretty detailed, but the text has jagged edges all around them no matter what quality you print at. The paper intake mechanism can be unforgiving with few sheets of paper in the tray. We had a few misaligned prints.

The Epson Stylus C110 isn't a bad printer, but it

isn't a brilliant one either. For its price, it's a tiny bit costlier than it should have been. Its speed and detailed prints are pretty good. As an everyday printer for text printouts and occasional photo prints, it's a decent buy.

Specifications:
Dimensions: 43.5 x 24 x 16 cm, Noise levels: 39 dB, Weight: 3.9 kg, Ink cartridges: Black (2), Cyan, Magenta, Yellow.

Contact: Epson India
Phone: 30515000
E-mail: sales@eid.epson.co.in
Web site: www.epson.co.in
Price: Rs 5,299

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

ASUS Formula Rampage X48 Makes A Late Entry

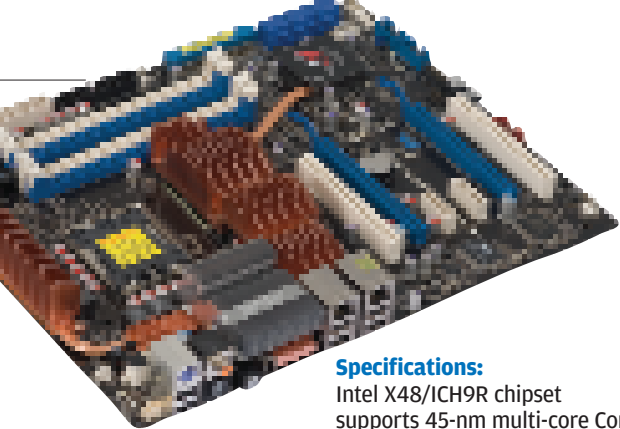
ASUS's Formula Rampage is an X48-based motherboard that supports Crossfire and sticks to DDR2 memory. The launch is timed at around the same time as nVidia's 790i-based motherboards, which use DDR3. With DDR3 still not very affordable for the masses and not quite showing any major performance improvements, the X48 might stand a good chance to take the place of the X38.

The motherboard has been stacked with heat sinks with copper pipes forming a long continuous chain evenly distributing heat. It does a great job at that and there are no noticeable hotspots anywhere. Solid state capacitors are used all over the board. At the rear of the board, an LED display shows information and errors while posting. The BIOS has a sec-

tion called the AI Tweaker, which has plenty to keep the overclocker busy with reasonably minute increments for speeds and voltages.

In terms of performance, it's general. There are no real benefits that one can find on the X48 chipset. Most processors today still use the 1333 MHz FSB. The motherboard performs as well as well as the high-end P35 boards. In 3DMark 2005, it scores 27927, which matches the high-end P35 boards of last year, but shows a very miniature improvement in games like Splinter Cell and Doom 3 at high resolutions.

The board comes with SupremeFX II's riser card for audio. Software bundled with the board is 3DMark 2006 and a DirectX 10 version of Stalker.



In the end, the X48 stands out as nothing but just a minor update for the X38. The performance gain is minimal, but the board is a little more future-ready, which should interest anyone who initially planned to get an X38. This is an enthusiast-level board that matches some of the best P35 and X38 boards so the price of Rs 17,400 is overpriced as compared to the best performing boards from a few months back.

Specifications:
Intel X48/ICH9R chipset supports 45-nm multi-core Core 2 Quad/Duo/Extreme CPUs, Dual Channel DDR2 1066MHz support.

Contact: ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd
Phone: 18002090365
E-mail: media.india@asus.com
Web site: http://in.asus.com
Price: Rs 17,400

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆